

Facebook Lite

Facebook launches optimised version of its well known social networking site

DirectX 11 for laptops

Mobile version of AMD's DirectX 11 chipsets rumoured to be out this November

Motherboard test

stayed pretty much the same. While looking at the scores between a Core 2 QX9650 and the Core i7 975 processor for a moment, we see an especially large improvement in the CPU intensive benchmarks such as the DivX file conversion test and Cinebench.

Intel Core 2 Boards (Discrete Graphics)

The Intel LGA775 legacy finally comes to an end. In a year's time, there's no telling if we'll still see as many LGA775 boards as we do now. The Core i5 is finally coming in to replace the Core 2 line of processors.

Design and features

The Gigabyte EP45-UD3R is one of the high-end P45 boards in the market. Gigabyte has made a name for itself especially for its P45 boards. The cooling solution is one of the newer styles used by Gigabyte with the blue badge heatsinks and anodized heat pipes connecting them together. This board only has one PCIe x16 slot so this isn't for anyone looking for a CrossFire solution. There are 3 PCI slots and one PCIe x1 slot under the x16 slot. Two of the other x1 slots are placed above. There is no x4 slot, so no x4 cards can be put on this board. One of the x1 slots almost touches the heat sink and the other can be used as long as the cards aren't long and touching the RAM modules. The SATA ports point upwards and are placed out of the path of a PCIe graphics card. There are no fancy power buttons or LED displays on this motherboard.

The Gigabyte EP43T-UD3L based on the slightly inferior P43 chipset supports DDR3 RAM. Like the EP45-UD3R, this one too lacks a x4 slot. X1 slots on the other hand are in abundance and there are also two PCI slots. The x1 slots can accommodate sound cards or any other similar cards as long as they don't aling with the RAM slots.

There are two isolated heatsinks for the Northbridge and the Southbridge without any interconnecting heat pipes. They do a decent job of keeping things under control. The good thing about this setup is also that the area around the CPU is kept clear so attaching huge heatsinks and fans is simple.

The MSI P45 Diamond is another DDR3 motherboard for the enthusiast. The size of the box gives that away. Although, it's a high-end board, it doesn't match up to the style and design of the ASUS ROG series as such. For example, the power, reset and CMOS clear buttons look really cheap and bigger, better designed buttons would've been a nice thing to have when you pay so much for a board like this. The primary heat sink supports water

cooling if you plan on buying a water cooling kit. There is a transparent panel covering the top with provision for water inlet and outlet. The board runs perfectly cool with just the passive cooling solution though. This one also happens to be one of the brightest boards with loads of multicoloured bright LEDs. There aren't any issues or complaints about the board but the problem is that there isn't anything special with it either.

MSI P45 Neo2 is based on the P45 chipset as well but is a slightly less expensive board. The cooling is done by two blocks of heatsinks one for the Northbridge and the other for the Southbridge, both connected by a heat pipe. There are two PCIe x1 slots adjacent to the first PCIe x16 slot out of which one will get obstructed by a single slot graphics card.

The space around the processor is relatively clear without any heat pipes or heatsinks in that region

There are no optical or SPDIF connectors at the back either.

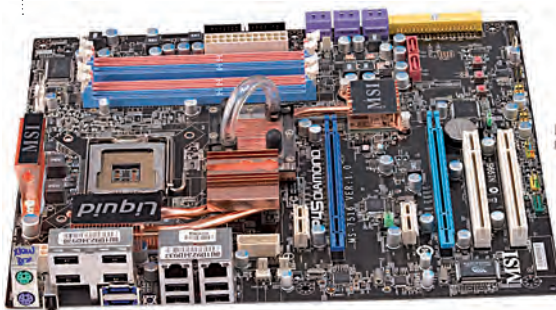
BioStar's TPower I45 board comes with an add-on heatsink and fan that can be mounted on one of the heatsinks on this board. The first slot has



Biostar TPower I45

a long queue of jumpers right under the first PCIe x16 slot which like some of the Gigabyte boards can block a fan on an open card design. The jumpers are meant for configuring the PCIe slots. Biostar has got a good design with this board and a lot of it has been laid out rather well. Installing our huge Cooler Master TX2 cooler was hassle free. The processor socket is placed on the extreme top end of the board and the heatsinks surround the area have been cut low.

The ASUS Maximus II Gene is very much like the Rampage II Gene except that the Maximus is based on the P45. The Southbridge heat sink is slightly banked so it doesn't come in the way of the graphics card. The memory slots have a one-sided clip. This is another board from the RoG (Republic of Gamers) range from ASUS.



MSI P45 Diamond



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